9. Myth Busting

9.1. Spiking only happens to young women.

Spiking can happen to anyone, no matter age or gender, sexuality or ethnicity. 9% of men and 13% of women responding to a 2022 survey, reported having been spiked in their lifetime. In the following year, 2.1% of men and 2.3% of women reported being spiked in the previous 12 months, almost an even split.[13]

9.2. Spiking is only done by strangers.

Spiking can be done by people we know as well as strangers. Research from 2022 found that in nearly 30% of self-reported spiking incidents, the perpetrator was someone the survivor knew[13].

9.3. Spiking only involves illegal drugs.

Many different drugs can be used in spiking, including prescription and illicit drugs as well as alcohol. A study from Students Organising for Sustainability in 2021 found that the most common substance used in spiking was alcohol[26]. This can be adding alcohol to non-alcoholic beverages and adding/ increasing strength of an already alcoholic beverage.

9.4. Spiking is only illegal if it leads to another crime.

Spiking is illegal regardless of the intent, be it to commit another crime or prank someone, including if nothing else happened after the spiking. It is a crime under multiple laws, including the Offences Against the Person Act[27], and carries a sentence of up to ten years in prison. If the spiking is followed by another crime, the sentence might be even longer[8].

9.5. I can't report spiking if I've taken other drugs willingly.

It's not a crime to have drugs in your system unless you're driving, so don't let this stop you reporting a spiking incident[7]. Police may ask you if you have taken anything, to help identify what you have taken willingly yourself and what might have been used for spiking. This is important for both investigative and intelligence purposes.

9.6. Spiking survivors have just had too much to drink.

Spiking can happen regardless of whether you've been drinking, or taking drugs, and survivors are never to blame. Although it can be hard to tell if someone has been spiked or had too much to drink (as the symptoms are very similar)[7], it's important to make sure you're safe and have medical attention if you need it.

9.7. Police and/or venue staff won't take me seriously.

Police officers are trained to understand and support victims of crime, and police work with venues to train staff to recognise and respond to spiking. A survey of 28 night-life venues in Cambridgeshire shows that 86% of them implemented initiatives related to drink spiking[13].